

AI-Designed Portrait Guide #006



Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10-14 hours Subject Male Portrait / Close-Up Face Study

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

Every guide in this series is generated by Claude — an AI trained on professional art instruction, anatomy theory, color science, and fine arts critique frameworks. It analyzes the reference, identifies the technical challenges, and writes a sequenced plan before I touch a pencil.

Then I follow it exactly and document what happens — so the results are verifiable, not theoretical.

At the end of each guide, there's a prompt you can run on your own work to get the same level of critique.

PENCIL & PROMPT

• COLOR PALETTE



30% Warm Grey

PC1052

Chromatic shadow base — avoids neutral grey deadness; warm cast creates luminous darks



50% Warm Grey

PC1054

Mid-shadow chromatic anchor; bridges cool undertone and warm reflected light



Henna

PC1031

Warm shadow deepening; red-brown chromatic shadow in eye sockets and cheek hollows



Beige Sienna

PC1080

Warm shadow-to-midtone transitional layer; earthy anchor for skin depth



Nectar

PC1092

Rich warm mid-shadow with peachy undertone; optical mixer for shadow luminosity



Ginger Root

PC1084

Warm mid-tone bridge; prevents harsh transitions between shadow and light



Bronze

PC1028

Chromatic shadow deepener with golden undertone; sculpts facial planes without deadening



Rosy Beige

PC1019

Primary midtone for skin; warm with subtle rosiness matching portrait lighting



Beige

PC997

Neutral-warm midtone; optical mixer for lighter skin passages without oversaturation



Clay Rose

PC1017

Muted transitional tone; connects cool shadows to warm midtones without abruptness



Peach

PC939

Main warm light-zone local color; foundation for photorealistic peachy glow



Salmon Pink

PC1001

Warm light with cool-pink undertone; reflects atmospheric and ambient light in shadows



Blush Pink

PC928

Local color intensifier in cheeks, lips, ear rims; warm pinkish local color



Deco Peach

PC1013

Ultra-soft warm highlight prep layer; barely-there peachy veil before creams



Peach Beige

PC1085

Luminous light-zone transitional; bridges peach and white highlights smoothly



Cream

PC914

Warm off-white for soft highlights; creates glow without cool starkness of pure white



White

PC938

Final brightest highlights; used sparingly on forehead peak, nose tip, eye catch lights



Tuscan Red

PC937

Deep chromatic shadow in eye sockets and severe folds; muted red preserves skin realism

SUBJECT IDENTIFICATION

<i>What is the subject?</i>	Closeup male portrait; front-facing face with gentle three- quarter lighting suggestion; soft focus suggests professional portrait photography with shallow depth of field.
<i>Material characteristics</i>	Human skin with warm peachy-pink undertone throughout; appears to have light makeup or natural flush; luminous quality suggests professional lighting rig with fill light and possible reflector.
<i>Geometric structure</i>	Oval face shape; proportional features; soft jawline; forehead-to-chin ratio suggests balanced mature face; cheekbones define mid-face structure; eye placement symmetrical with slight luminosity emphasis.

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

<i>Light source direction</i>	Soft diffused light source from upper-left front (approximately 45° angle); suggests large reflective panel or window fill; creates gentle modeling without harsh shadows.
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HIGHLIGHT

Forehead apex (center-upper), cheekbone peaks, bridge of nose, eye inner canthi catch lights; these areas maintain maximum luminosity with warm peachy glow.

LIGHT AREA

Upper cheeks, temple areas, nose bridge; full saturation of warm peachy-pink local color; minimal shadow intrusion.

MIDTONE

Cheek planes, side of nose, upper lip area, forehead lower third; transition zone where local color modulates with subtle shadow suggestion; approximately 60% of facial area.

SHADOW

Eye socket recesses, under-cheekbone hollows, side of neck, jaw shadows; moderate depth; reads as warm-brown rather than cool-grey due to atmospheric fill light.

CAST SHADOW

Minimal cast shadow visible; some definition under nose and slight shadow cast from head on neck; suggests overhead or frontal fill minimizes hard shadows.

<i>Edge quality notes</i>	Soft focus rendering suggests shallow depth of field; edges between features dissolve into background; sharp focus primarily on forward-facing eye and cheek plane; background extremely soft and bokeh-like, creating zero distraction.
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COLOR ANALYSIS

<i>Overall temperature</i>	Distinctly warm overall; peachy-pink dominant cast throughout; no cool blues or greens visible; suggests warm color-temperature lighting (tungsten or warm LED).
<i>Light zone tendency</i>	Light areas trend toward peach, salmon-pink, and warm cream tones; luminous glow rather than stark white; suggests reflected

warmth from skin itself and warm fill light.

Shadow zone tendency

Shadows retain warmth; read as warm brown-reds (siennas, henna tones) rather than purple or cool grey; indicates warm fill light and atmospheric scattering of warm light into shadows.

Special color areas

Lips and cheeks show intensified warm pink-red local color; iris likely warm brown or hazel with warm light reflection; ear rims show translucent peachy tone where light passes through.

Saturation distribution

Highest saturation in cheek/blush areas and lips; mid-saturation in main skin passages; lowest saturation in shadows where colors become muted warm-browns; no overly saturated hues create garish effect.

O1 Step 1: Contour & Value Map Foundation

Entire face — proportional mapping and lightest initial tone layer

Feather-light directional layering; circular and planar strokes following anatomical form; no burnishing pressure

Light pressure

Using a 2H mechanical pencil, lightly establish feature placement and proportions without heavy pressure; map all major planes (forehead, cheek planes, nose planes, jaw). With feather-light pressure, lay down PC1052 30% Warm Grey as an all-over wash to establish the lowest common denominator of skin value. This chromatic shadow base prevents dead neutrality and creates luminous foundation. Keep pressure so light that pencil texture barely registers; aim for smooth, even coverage across all skin areas. Use directional strokes following facial form (downward on cheeks, circular on forehead) to suggest subtle form without line quality.

COLORS  PC1052 30% Warm Grey

◆ *This foundational warm-grey establishes chromatic bias immediately — it prevents the common colored pencil trap of muddy skin created by cool greys layered under warm tones. The warm undertone 'glows' upward through subsequent layers.*

O2 Step 2: Shadow Zone Chromatic Depth

Eyebrow recesses, under-cheekbone hollows, jaw shadow, neck side, nostril interiors

Circular strokes in shadow zones; medium-light pressure; tortillon softening on edges

Medium pressure

Layer PC1054 50% Warm Grey over previous layer in all shadow areas, building depth without losing the foundational glow. This mid-value chromatic grey bridges the lightest base and darkest shadow tones. Use medium-light pressure in circular motions within shadow regions, being careful not to overshoot into light areas. The 50% grey sits exactly between the initial 30% and the darker chromatic shadows you'll add next, creating invisible transition. Pay special attention to eye socket corners and the subtle shadow under the cheekbone — these zones set the facial structure's credibility. Blend slightly with a tortillon where edges need softening.

COLORS  PC1054 50% Warm Grey

◆ *Resist the urge to go dark immediately. Layered warm-greys create far more luminous depth than single dark strokes. Each grey layer optically mixes with the one below, creating warmth without muddiness.*

03

Step 3: Warm Shadow Deepening with Siennas

Eysocket recesses(innerandoutercorners),temple shadows, cheek underplane, jaw definition, neck shadow areas

Medium pressure circular strokes in shadow zones; graduated layering allowing previous layers to show through

Medium pressure

Introduce PC1080 Beige Sienna into the deepest shadow regions, layering directly over the 50% grey. Sienna's earthy red-brown warmth creates sculptural depth while preserving the warm glow principle. Use medium pressure, applying in small circular motions within shadow areas; this sienna should enhance the underlying grey structure, not replace it. Focus on creating a subtle gradient from grey → sienna at shadow edges, allowing previous layers to remain visible in transition zones. The sienna 'sings' the warm undertone of real skin shadow, far more convincing than pure brown or purple. Keep the sienna's saturation controlled — aim for muted, earthy application rather than bright rust.

COLORS

PC1080 Beige Sienna

◆ *Sienna in shadow creates the 'warmth in darkness' that photorealistic skin rendering demands. The undertone shifts from grey → sienna throughout the shadow zone, suggesting both structural form and warm light influence.*

04 Step 4: Red-Brown Chromatic Shadow Accents

Deepest shadow pockets: eye socket recesses, under-cheekbone hollow definition, side of nose shadow bridge, jawline shadow depth

Medium-heavy pressure in isolated deep-shadow zones; immediate tortillon softening of henna edges

Medium-Heavy pressure

Layer PC1031 Henna (warm red-brown) into only the deepest shadow areas where maximum depth is needed. This is not applied all over shadows — only in recessed zones where light is genuinely blocked. Use medium-to-medium-heavy pressure in very localized areas, creating small zones of intense warm-red-brown depth. The henna should appear as embedded darkness with warm red undertone, suggesting the actual reddish tone of skin in deepest shadow. Blend the henna's edge into the surrounding sienna with a tortillon, preventing harsh edge. This step defines facial structure; overdoing it destroys the portrait, so apply sparingly and assess frequently.

COLORS

■ PC1031 Henna

◆ *Henna is the shadow 'anchor' — it establishes maximum contrast and form definition. But its impact is only credible if surrounded by transitional grey and sienna layers. Never apply henna directly to white paper.*

05

Step 5: Tuscan Red Deepest Shadow Structure

Innereye socket corners, centraleye socket recess depth, most severe cheekbone underplane hollow at apex

Very localized medium-heavy pressure strokes; immediate tortillon softening; minimal visible application

Medium-Heavy pressure

Using PC937 Tuscan Red, apply only to the absolute deepest recessed areas where shadow is most profound. This muted burgundy-red is deeper and cooler than henna, creating the visual 'pit' that eye sockets and severe hollows require. Apply with medium-heavy pressure in tiny, isolated zones; this is subtle work requiring restraint. A small tortillon immediately softens the Tuscan red's outer edge into the henna layer, creating seamless transition. The goal is suggestion of maximum depth with minimal application — Tuscan red appears as embedded shadow structure, not as a visible color layer. After application, assess whether the contrast serves the portrait's dimensionality; overstated use reads as 'painting' rather than 'portraiture.'

COLORS

■ PC937 Tuscan Red

◆ *Tuscan red in deepest shadow zones prevents flat dark areas from reading as pure black or muddy brown. The muted burgundy undertone keeps darkest shadows 'warm' and skin-like, never dead or ashen.*

06 Step 6: Transitional Layer — Clay Rose Bridge

All shadow-to-midtone edges; cheek outer edges, temple sides, lower forehead sides, jaw transition to light

Medium-light directional pressure following facial form; feathered edge blending with tortillon

Medium pressure

Layer PC1017 Clay Rose across all areas where dark shadow transitions into lighter midtone. This muted rosy-warm tone is specifically designed for this role — it's neither shadow nor light, but the critical bridge between them. Apply medium-light pressure in directional strokes following the facial form (e.g., downward strokes on temple-to-cheek transition). The clay rose should create an invisible graduated zone where shadow and light merge without abrupt value jumps. This layer is crucial for avoiding the 'striped' appearance of colored pencil work where separate color layers remain visibly stacked. Blend slightly with a tortillon where the clay rose meets adjacent colors, feathering its edges.

COLORS

■ PC1017 Clay Rose

◆ *Clay rose is the unsung hero of portrait realism — it's subtle enough that viewers never consciously see it, but without it, the portrait reads as color blocks rather than luminous form. Think of it as the optical mixer that makes separated layers disappear.*

07 Step 7: Midtone Foundation — Rosy Beige Wash

All non-shadow areas; cheekplanes, forehead, side of nose, upper lip, chin light side

Medium-light directional pressure; semi-transparent layering allowing underlayers to influence final tone; circular strokes on rounded forms

Medium pressure

Apply PC1019 Rosy Beige with medium-light pressure in smooth, directional strokes across all skin areas that haven't received deep shadow treatment. This is the primary midtone — warm, slightly rosy, and the visual 'anchor' of the portrait's color temperature. Build coverage gradually, allowing underlying layers (particularly the initial 30% grey and clay rose transitions) to influence the rosy beige's final appearance. The rosy beige optically mixes with warm greys below, creating dimensional warm tone rather than flat warm color. Avoid heavy, opaque application; aim for a semi-transparent layer that respects underlying structure. This layer should read as 'skin tone' — not garish, not muddy, but luminously warm.

COLORS

■ PC1019 Rosy Beige

✦ *Rosy beige is the color note that unifies the portrait — it's warm enough to read as living skin, but rosy enough to suggest the flush of light and health. Its semi-transparency is essential; heavy application looks artificial.*

o8 Step 8: Warm Light Midtone — Ginger Root Layering

Mid-light areas; cheek outer/upper planes, forehead mid-zones, temple inner areas, jaw light side

Medium-light circular pressure following form; graduated layering with semi-transparency

Medium pressure

Layer PC1084 Ginger Root over rosy beige in mid-light areas, creating a warmer, slightly more saturated midtone. This earthy warm tone adds dimension without jumping to full highlight brightness. Apply medium-light pressure, using small circular strokes that follow the cheekbone structure and forehead planes. The ginger root should feel like a warmed-up version of rosy beige — same family, higher warmth and subtle earthiness. Build in graduated layers, allowing some rosy beige to remain visible in the lightest portions of mid-light areas. This creates a subtle warm-gradient from cool-shadow through neutral-rosy to warm-earthy light zones, avoiding flat color application.

COLORS

■ PC1084 Ginger Root

◆ *Ginger root adds the 'warmth suggestion' without forcing full saturation — it whispers warmth rather than shouts it. This restraint is critical for photorealism; oversaturated skin tones read as makeup, not living complexion.*

09 Step 9: Reflected Light in Shadow — Salmon Pink Glow

Shadow zones receiving ambient/reflected light; under-cheekbone hollow inner edge, side of eye socket receiving rim light, jaw shadow inner edge, neck shadow areas

Light-to-medium-light localized pressure; strategic placement along shadow edges;
immediate tortillon softening

Medium pressure

Introduce PC1001 Salmon Pink into shadow areas where reflected light from surrounding warm environment bounces back into recessed zones. This is not a light color but a warm light-influenced color inserted into shadow to suggest atmospheric fill. Apply medium-light pressure in thin, carefully placed strokes within shadows, particularly along edges where shadow meets light. The salmon pink creates visual 'breathing room' in shadow areas, preventing them from reading as dead zones. Keep application subtle and localized — the salmon pink should suggest 'reflected warmth' rather than appear as a separate color block. Blend slightly with a tortillon where salmon pink meets adjacent shadow tones.

COLORS

■ PC1001 Salmon Pink

◆ *Salmon pink in shadows is the 'atmosphere' layer — it proves that light (even reflected light) penetrates shadow zones, preventing the dead appearance of pure dark. Professional portraiture always shows subtle warm glow even in darkest shadow areas.*

IO

Step 10: Local Color Intensification — Blush Pink Cheeks & Lips

Cheekapexes, lipfullnesszones, earriminneredges, nostrilinnerrim

Medium pressure circular strokes on cheeks; directional pressure on lips; light pressure on ear rims; semi-transparent layering

Medium pressure

Apply PC928 Blush Pink with medium pressure, focusing on natural flush areas where skin capillaries and local color intensity create visible pinkish tone. This is applied over the established midtone foundation (rosy beige, ginger root), intensifying warmth in these specific zones. Use small circular motions on cheek apexes, creating a soft bloom that suggests natural flush rather than makeup application. On lips, apply directional strokes following lip form, leaving some underlying tone visible to maintain dimension. On ear rims (if visible), use light pressure to suggest the translucent peachy-pink where light passes through thin skin. The blush pink should look like it belongs to the face, not applied on top of it — semi-transparency and careful placement are essential.

COLORS

 PC928 Blush Pink

♦ *Blush pink is about suggestion, not statement — the most beautiful portraits show subtle local color, never garish makeup. Apply with the assumption that viewers will only consciously register 'healthy glow,' not 'visible pink pencil stroke.'*

II Step 11: Light Zone Preparation — Deco Peach Veil

All light-to-mid-light areas: forehead, cheekbone peaks, nose bridge, upper lip highlight

Very light directional pressure; barely-visible wash application; multiple subtle passes

Light pressure

Layer PC1013 Deco Peach in a barely-visible wash across all areas that will receive the brightest highlights. This extremely pale peachy tone prepares the paper for warm highlight application, creating a soft peachy underpainting that white and cream highlights will sit atop. Apply with very light pressure in smooth, even strokes; the deco peach should be almost imperceptible at this stage, serving as tonal/chromatic preparation rather than visible color. This layer prevents highlights from reading as stark white against darker midtones — instead, the peach creates a graduated transition from midtone → deco peach → cream → white. Build the layer gradually over 2-3 passes, allowing paper tooth to remain available for the cream and white layers to come.

COLORS

 PC1013 Deco Peach

♦ *Deco peach is invisible in the final portrait, but its absence would be immediately apparent as a cold, jarring transition from warm midtone to white highlight. Always pre-warm highlight zones with a pale color matching your overall temperature.*

I2 Step 12: Luminous Light Foundation — Peach Core

Light-zone primary areas: cheekbone peaks, forehead highlights, nose bridge, temple highlights

Medium-light circular/directional pressure following form; graduated layering; selective application emphasizing convex highlights

Medium pressure

Apply PC939 Peach with medium-light pressure in smooth strokes to all primary light zones. This is the color note that defines the portrait's warm, luminous character — it's distinctly peachy without being orange or coral. Build in graduated layers, allowing the underlying deco peach and midtones to influence final appearance. The peach should read as 'saturated light' — warmer and more vivid than midtones, but not fluorescent or artificial. Use small circular strokes on convex forms (cheekbone peaks, forehead bulge), allowing strokes to follow the facial structure. Leave some underlying tones visible in transitional edges, creating graduated zones rather than abrupt color changes. The peach is applied with restraint — it's present but not dominant, establishing warmth without overwhelming.

COLORS

 PC939 Peach

♦ *Peach is the 'color statement' of the portrait — it's the warmth that viewers interpret as 'healthy, luminous skin.' Its success depends entirely on everything beneath it; without transitional layers, peach read as flat surface color rather than glowing from within.*

13

Step 13: Soft Highlight Brightening — Peach Beige & Cream

Brightest non-apex light areas: upper cheekbones, forehead mid-zones, side of nose catches

Medium pressure for peach beige; very light pressure for cream; feathered edges with tortillon; multiple subtle passes building brightness

Varies pressure

Layer PC1085 Peach Beige with medium pressure over peach in mid-light zones, creating luminous bridging between peach intensity and white highlights. Then introduce PC914 Cream with very light pressure in the actual brightest non-apex zones (not forehead peak or nose tip apex, but the bright surroundings). The peach beige optically mixes with peach below, warming it subtly; the cream begins the transition toward white. Use very small, controlled strokes, building brightness gradually through multiple light passes rather than single heavy applications. The cream should appear as barely-visible luminosity, setting the stage for white highlight's final impact. Blend cream's edges slightly with a tortillon to prevent any visible pencil texture in these bright zones.

COLORS



PC1085 Peach Beige



PC914 Cream

◆ *Cream and peach beige create the 'glow zone' that surrounds white highlights — they prevent white from appearing as stark artificial spots. The transition from peach → peach beige → cream → white should be so graduated that each step is barely perceptible.*

I4 Step 14: Apex Highlights — White Final Accents

Brightest highlights: forehead peak, nose tip apex, eye inner-corner catch lights, cheekbone apex reflections

Very light-to-light precision pressure; single confident strokes with sharp point; extreme restraint in application area

Light pressure

Apply PC938 White with very light-to-light pressure in only the most extreme highlight zones — forehead highest point, nose tip apex, eye catch lights, and cheekbone peak reflections. This is restraint work; white highlights should occupy perhaps 2-5% of the portrait's total area, making their impact maximal through scarcity. Use extremely sharp pencil tip (freshly rotary-sharpened) for precise point placement. Apply in single, confident strokes rather than repeated small marks; white pencil visibly layers unless applied with intention. The white should appear to glow from within, not sit on top of the portrait. After applying white, immediately assess — white overapplication is the most common colored pencil error, making portraits appear toy-like or synthetic.

COLORS



PC938 White

◆ *White highlights are the portrait's visual punctuation — they should feel inevitable, not applied. If viewers consciously notice the white highlights, you've applied too much. Ideally, they perceive the glow without detecting the pencil strokes.*

I5

Step 15: Detail Refinement & Edge Quality

Feature edges and details: eye iris inner detail, eyelid definition, eyebrow structure, lip contour edges, nostril rims

Very sharp pencil point; variable pressure from light to medium; directional strokes following feature forms; selective edge crisping

Varies pressure

Using sharp pencil points with colors appropriate to each feature (henna or bronze for eye socket definition, peach or blush for lip edges), refine feature edges and add final detail structure. This step assumes the portrait's foundation is complete; now focus on crispening edges where appropriate (eye definition, lip contours) while maintaining soft edges elsewhere (cheek to background transition). Use very light-to-medium pressure with directional strokes; avoid harsh lines. The goal is to define features through subtle color and value shifts, not through pencil outlines. Pay special attention to iris rendering if visible — layer warm browns or golds with tiny strokes following iris structure, then add a precise white highlight dot on the upper-inner iris. This step transforms an almost-finished portrait into a precisely-finished portrait through selective crisp-edge detail work.

COLORS

PC1031 Henna

PC1028 Bronze

PC939 Peach

PC928 Blush Pink

PC938 White

✦ *Detail work is where amateurs overtighten and professionals stay loose — resist the urge to outline features. Edges should shift through subtle color/value change, not through drawn lines. Iris detail is tiny work; the white dot should be microscopically placed at the 1 o'clock position of the iris, barely visible but optically transforming the eye's vitality.*

I6 Step 16: Burnishing & Atmospheric Integration

Entire portrait — final luminosity and cohesion integration

Light-pressure circular motions with colorless blender; medium-tooth paper block flat-surface blending; minimal pressure to avoid plastic appearance

Light pressure

Using a colorless blender or the side of a sharp white pencil (PC938) applied with minimal pressure, lightly burnish all mid-light areas where color layers have been built. This melts all visible pencil texture into a smooth, luminous surface without adding new color. Work gently in small circular motions, particularly across cheeks, forehead, and nose — these convex forms benefit most from burnishing. Use a medium-tooth paper block held flat against the portrait's surface, applying light pressure in circular motions to further blend visible color transitions. The goal is optical color integration — viewers should perceive 'glowing skin,' not 'layered colored pencil.' Avoid over-burnishing, which can make skin appear plastic or wax-like; stop when the surface feels dimensionally luminous rather than slick. Finally, step back 2-3 feet from the completed work, assessing overall value distribution, color temperature consistency, and the portrait's 'atmospheric' presence.

COLORS

● PC938 White

✦ *Burnishing is finishing, not fixing — if undertaken after full color establishment, it should meld existing layers into seamless luminosity. Over-aggressive burnishing destroys the subtle optical mixing and makes skin appear synthetic. When in doubt, stop early; it's far easier to add more detail to luminous, natural-looking skin than to recover from over-burnished plastic appearance.*

Evaluate Your Result

Upload your finished drawing to Claude and use this prompt:

"I followed a colored pencil portrait tutorial. Here's what I was trying to achieve: [describe the portrait].
Here's what I think went well: [your observation].
Here's what I'm not satisfied with: [your concern].
Give me 2-3 specific things to improve and rate the result 1-10."

Guide #006 · Pencil & Prompt

This guide was part of an ongoing series — each one AI-generated, human-executed, fully documented.

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